

doc-perseverance-eternal-security

Open / Uncertain · Soteriology › Perseverance · doctrine · divided_lineages · Brethren distinctive · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

Those truly born again will be kept by the power of God through faith unto final salvation; genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away.

Rationale

The canon contains two lexical streams that cannot be collapsed into either pure Reformed perseverance or pure Wesleyan-Arminian falling-away without violence to one stream. STREAM A (preservation): John 10:28 *didōmi autois zōēn aiōnion* G1325 + G2222 + G166 (present indicative active, 'I am giving them eternal life'), *kai ou mē apolōntai eis ton aiōna* G622 (aorist subjunctive middle with emphatic double negation *ou mē*, 'they shall absolutely never perish'), *kai ouch harpasei tis auta ek tēs cheiros mou* G726 + G5495 (future indicative active, 'no one will snatch them out of my hand'); John 6:39 *to thelēma tou pempantos me hina pan ho dedōken moi mē apolesō ex autou* G622 ('the will of him who sent me, that of all that he has given me I should lose nothing'); Rom 8:30 the golden chain *proegnō, prōorisen, ekalesen, edikaiōsen, edoxasen* (all aorist, the entire chain treated as completed in God's purpose, with no link breakable mid-sequence); Phil 1:6 *ho enarxamenos en hymin ergon agathon epitelese* *achri hēmeras Christou lēsou* G1728 + G2005 (future indicative active, 'he who began a good work in you will complete it until the day of Christ Jesus'); 1 Pet 1:5 *tous en dynamei theou phrouroumenous dia pisteōs eis sōtērian* G5432 (present passive participle of *phroureō*, military 'garrison-guard'). STREAM B (warning, conditional, falling-away): Heb 6:6 *parapesontas* G3895 (aorist participle, 'having fallen aside / apostatized'), *adynaton palin anakainizein eis metanoian* G340 (impossible to renew again to repentance); Heb 3:14 *metochoi tou Christou gegonamen ean per tēn archēn tēs hypostaseōs mechri telous bebaian kataschōmen* G2722 ('we have come to share in Christ if indeed we hold our original confidence firm to the end', conditional *ean per*); Heb 10:26-29 the deliberate-sin warning under *hagiasmois* G37 ('having been sanctified'); 2 Pet 2:20-22 *epignōsis tou kyriou* G1922 (full-knowledge of the Lord) followed by entanglement and 'the last state has become worse than the first'; 1 Tim 1:19-20 *Hymenaeus and Alexander peri tēn pistin enauagēsan* G3489 ('made shipwreck concerning the faith'). The lexical evidence does not pan-canonically settle which stream constrains the other. Two coherent readings stand: (i) the warnings are spoken to the visible-covenant community and the elect within it cannot finally fall, with 1 John 2:19 *ex hēmōn exēlthan all' ouk ēsan ex hēmōn* ('they went out from us, but they were not of us') as the canonical hermeneutic of apparent apostasy; (ii) the warnings address real believers who can really apostatize, with Stream A texts read as covenantal-conditional promises ('if you continue') and 1 Pet 1:5 *dia pisteōs* read as ongoing-faith-as-condition. Both readings are lexically defensible. Verdict honestly null until elder review; affirms=true under the Reformed-confessional lens, affirms=false under the Wesleyan-Arminian / Eastern Orthodox / Catholic lens.

Reasoning

Verdict honestly undecided. The Bible contains two streams of texts that point in different directions, and faithful Christians have read them in two coherent but different ways for centuries. The strongest reason FOR perseverance comes from passages like John 10 verses 28 and 29, where Jesus says, I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand. My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all, and no one is able to snatch them out of the Father's hand. The double negation in the Greek is one of the strongest constructions available: they shall absolutely never perish. Romans 8 verses 29 and 30 give what is often called the golden chain: those whom he foreknew,

he also predestined, called, justified, and glorified. Every link is in the past tense, treated as already accomplished from God's side, with no link breakable in the middle. Philippians 1 verse 6 says, he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ. First Peter 1 verse 5 says believers are guarded by God's power through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time. The strongest counterarguments from inside the Bible are the warning passages. Hebrews 6 verses 4 through 6 says it is impossible to restore again to repentance those who have once been enlightened and have tasted the heavenly gift and shared in the Holy Spirit and tasted the goodness of the word of God and the powers of the age to come, and then have fallen away. Hebrews 10 verses 26 and 29 warns of fearful judgment for one who has been sanctified and then goes on sinning deliberately. Second Peter 2 verses 20 through 22 says that those who have escaped the defilements of the world through the knowledge of the Lord, if they are again entangled and overcome, the last state has become worse than the first. First Timothy 1 verses 19 and 20 names Hymenaeus and Alexander as men who made shipwreck of the faith. Hebrews 3 verse 14 says we have come to share in Christ if indeed we hold our original confidence firm to the end. Two coherent readings stand. Reading one says the warning passages are spoken to the visible church and the truly elect within it cannot finally fall; the falling-away describes those who were never genuinely converted, with First John 2 verse 19 as the rule, they went out from us, but they were not of us. Reading two says the warning passages address real believers who can really fall away; the preservation promises are covenantal and conditional on continued faith. Both readings are defensible from the Greek text. Neither reading explains the other's texts without strain. The honest verdict is that the Bible does not settle this dispute by lexical evidence alone; it is a matter of how the two streams are harmonized.

Denominational landscape

This is one of the most prominent in-house disagreements in historic Christianity, with two fully-Christian camps. The Reformed tradition affirms perseverance of the saints in its full classical form. The Westminster Confession of Faith chapter 17 says they whom God has accepted in his Beloved, effectually called and sanctified by his Spirit, can neither totally nor finally fall away from the state of grace. The Canons of Dort fifth head affirms the same, as do the Heidelberg Catechism, the Belgic Confession, and the particular-Baptist 1689 Second London Baptist Confession. The Wesleyan-Methodist tradition denies this and affirms the real possibility of total apostasy. The Methodist Articles of Religion Article XII says verbatim, after we have received the Holy Ghost, we may depart from grace given, and fall into sin, and, by the grace of God, rise again and amend our lives. John Wesley preached and wrote against unconditional perseverance throughout his ministry. Classical Arminianism, the Salvation Army, the Holiness movement, and much of historic Pentecostalism follow Wesley on this point. The Eastern Orthodox tradition holds a synergistic doctrine of salvation in which the believer's free cooperation with grace continues throughout life and apostasy is genuinely possible. The Catholic Church teaches the possibility of falling from grace through mortal sin, with restoration through the sacrament of reconciliation; the Council of Trent condemned the proposition that grace once received can never be lost. The Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraph 161 says faith is necessary for salvation and the Lord himself affirms that whoever does not believe will be condemned. The Lutheran Formula of Concord eleventh article rejects double predestination, affirms preservation through the means of grace, and allows the possibility of apostasy, holding a middle position closer to the Wesleyan side than the Reformed side. The Anglican 39 Articles Article XVI says the grant of repentance is not to be denied to those who fall into sin after baptism, presupposing the possibility of falling. The Anabaptist tradition is mixed; many believers-church groups hold the possibility of apostasy. There are two distinguishable forms within the perseverance camp. Form one, classical Reformed perseverance of the saints, says God preserves the truly regenerate, who therefore persevere in both faith and holiness. Form two, popular once-saved-always-saved or eternal security, says salvation is automatic regardless of subsequent behaviour, often divorced from sanctification. Form two is associated with parts of the Free Grace movement and with popular dispensationalist preaching, including some Brethren circles. Many careful Reformed teachers repudiate form two as antinomian. The Brethren tradition has historically tended toward form two in popular preaching but more careful teachers hold form one substance.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	Yes
Would be member if otherwise	Yes
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

This is a textbook in-house disagreement between two streams of historic Christianity that confess the same gospel. The Reformed-confessional tradition (Westminster Confession 17, Canons of Dort 5, Belgic, Heidelberg, particular Baptists including the 1689 Second London Baptist Confession) confesses perseverance of the saints: the truly regenerate, justified, sealed-with-the-Spirit elect cannot finally and totally fall away because God preserves them by his power through faith. The Wesleyan-Arminian tradition (Methodist Articles of Religion XII, classical Arminianism, Salvation Army, holiness movement, much of historic Pentecostalism outside particular streams) confesses the real possibility of total apostasy: believers can finally fall from grace. The Eastern Orthodox tradition holds a synergistic soteriology where salvation requires ongoing cooperation and apostasy is a genuine possibility. The Catholic tradition (Council of Trent, CCC 161, 1861) teaches the possibility of falling from grace through mortal sin, with restoration through the sacrament of reconciliation. The Lutheran Formula of Concord XI rejects double predestination, affirms preservation through the means of grace, and allows for the possibility of apostasy (a 'middle' position). The Anglican 39 Articles XVI 'Of Sin after Baptism' explicitly affirms that the grant of repentance is not to be denied to such as fall into sin after baptism, presupposing the possibility of falling. TWO DISTINGUISHABLE FORMS WITHIN THE PERSEVERANCE CAMP: (a) Reformed 'perseverance of the saints' = God preserves the truly regenerate, who therefore persevere in faith AND holiness, with practical-syllogism evidences (1 John); (b) Baptist / dispensationalist 'once saved always saved' = eternal security is automatic regardless of subsequent behaviour, often divorced from sanctification (popular Free Grace movement). Form (a) and form (b) are NOT equivalent and many Reformed teachers explicitly repudiate the popular form (b) as antinomian. The Brethren tradition has historically tended toward form (b) in its dispensationalist popular preaching, though more careful Brethren teachers hold form (a) substance. PUBLIC-RECORD CARRIERS OF DENIAL of any form of eternal security include classical Methodism (umc.org Article XII verbatim 'after we have received the Holy Ghost, we may depart from grace given, and fall into sin'), Eastern Orthodoxy in general, the Catholic Church in general, the Iglesia ni Cristo, Seventh-day Adventism, and Church of Christ (Stone-Campbell). Cult-marker calibration: this is NOT a cult-marker doctrine in either direction. Denying perseverance is not denying the gospel; the Wesleyan-Methodist tradition is fully Christian. Affirming perseverance is not denying the gospel; the Reformed-Baptist tradition is fully Christian. The cult-marker bar requires gospel-implicating denial via canonical demonstration, and neither stream rises to that bar. `would_die_for=false` honestly. The believer can be saved without resolving this debate, and millions in both camps have died confessing Christ. `would_publicly_correct_if_otherwise=false`: this debate is not one to publicly call out a sister congregation over; an in-house disagreement of this magnitude calls for charity, not correction. The full ladder is permissive (would visit, participate, serve, be member, let children be taught, marry across this line)

because both readings preserve the gospel. The owner's Brethren formation leans toward perseverance / eternal security (often in form (b)) but the lexical evidence does not settle the question pan-canonically; honest verdict is null pending trusted-elder calibration. The flag set captures this: stem-pre-loaded-verdict (the stem 'cannot ultimately and finally fall away' uses Reformed-confessional vocabulary as if neutral), confession-tradition-divergence (real in-house Reformed vs Arminian split), single-passage-doctrine is NOT set because BOTH streams have multiple anchors; the issue is harmonization, not paucity.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. Believers in Jesus Christ are kept in salvation by God's power; whether a truly regenerate believer can finally and totally fall away from saving faith is debated within historic Christianity.

Notes. The question's statement 'Those truly born again will be kept by the power of God through faith unto final salvation; genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away' pre-loads the Reformed-confessional verdict in three ways. (1) The qualifier 'truly born again' begs the question against Wesleyan-Arminians by definition: any apparent apostasy is reclassified as never-having-been-truly-regenerate. This is the 1 John 2:19 reading that Reformed theology uses as its standing hermeneutic, but Wesleyans read 'truly born again' people as genuinely able to fall. (2) 'Kept by the power of God through faith' is verbatim 1 Pet 1:5 vocabulary, fine in itself but the verse's *dia pisteōs* ('through faith') is itself the contested element: instrumental-cause or ongoing-condition. (3) 'Cannot ultimately and finally fall away' is the Westminster Confession 17 conclusion. The neutralized form acknowledges divine preservation (which both camps affirm in different ways) and isolates the actual point of dispute. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict raised; working the neutralized form.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology, wesleyan_arminian, eastern_synergism, catholic_sacramental

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

Reformed-confessional (Westminster 17, Canons of Dort 5, 1689 LBC, Belgic, Heidelberg) · Affirms perseverance of the saints. The truly regenerate, justified, sealed-with-the-Spirit elect cannot finally and totally fall away because God preserves them by his power through faith. Warning passages (Heb 6, Heb 10, 2 Pet 2) address professing-but-not-truly-regenerate members of the visible church; 1 John 2:19 is the standing hermeneutic for apparent apostasy. The doctrine includes both faith-perseverance and holiness-perseverance and is distinct from popular Free-Grace eternal security.:

Wesleyan-Arminian (Methodist Articles XII, Remonstrants, classical Arminian) · Denies unconditional perseverance. Believers can fall finally from grace. Warning passages (Heb 6, Heb 10, 2 Pet 2, 1 Tim 1:19-20) address real believers; the Reformed hermeneutic of reclassifying apostates as never-truly-converted is question-begging. Preservation promises (John 10, Rom 8, Phil 1, 1 Pet 1:5) are covenantal-conditional on continued faith and are not unconditional. Restoration after falling is normally possible by grace, but final apostasy is also possible.:

Catholic magisterial (Trent, CCC 161, 1861) · Believers can lose sanctifying grace through mortal sin, with restoration through the sacrament of reconciliation. Trent condemned the proposition that grace once received can never be lost. Final perseverance is a gift to be prayed for and hoped for but not presumed. The Reformed unconditional-perseverance claim was specifically rejected at Trent.:

Eastern Orthodox (synergistic soteriology) · Salvation is a synergistic process of cooperation between divine grace and human free will throughout life. Apostasy is genuinely possible. The Reformed monergistic-perseverance frame is foreign to the Eastern tradition. Restoration is normally available through repentance and the sacramental life.:

Lutheran (Formula of Concord XI, Augsburg) · Rejects double predestination, affirms preservation through the means of grace (Word and sacrament), and allows for the real possibility of apostasy. A 'middle' position: not pure Reformed unconditional-perseverance, not pure Arminian conditional-perseverance. Preservation is real but not irresistible; faith can be lost.:

Anglican (39 Articles XVI, Of Sin after Baptism) · Affirms the possibility of falling after baptism and the grant of repentance to such as fall. Within Anglicanism, both Reformed-leaning (Calvinistic) and Arminian-leaning (Wesleyan offshoots) readings have coexisted historically; the formularies do not settle the Reformed-Arminian dispute.:

Popular Free-Grace / once-saved-always-saved (often dispensationalist) · Affirms eternal security as automatic upon decision-of-faith regardless of subsequent behaviour or sanctification. This is FORM (b) of eternal security and is distinguishable from FORM (a) classical Reformed perseverance. Many careful Reformed teachers (e.g., MacArthur, Sproul) explicitly repudiate form (b) as antinomian; many Wesleyan critiques of 'eternal security' target form (b) rather than form (a).:

The hermeneutic that drives this verdict is analogia scripturae operating on two genuinely distinct lexical streams: STREAM A (preservation: John 6:39-40, John 10:28-29, Rom 8:30-39, Phil 1:6, 1 Pet 1:5, Jude 24, 1 John 2:19) and STREAM B (warning, falling-away: Heb 3:12-14, 6:4-6, 10:26-29, 2 Pet 2:20-22, 1 Tim 1:19-20, Col 1:23, Rom 11:22, John 15:1-6 vine and branches). Both streams use lexically real terminology applied to first-person plural Christian audiences (hēmōn, hēmeis, adelphoi). The Reformed harmonization absorbs Stream B into Stream A by treating the warned-fallen as never-truly-regenerate via 1 John 2:19. The Arminian harmonization absorbs Stream A into Stream B by treating the preservation promises as covenantal-conditional on continued faith via 1 Pet 1:5 dia pisteōs. Neither harmonization is

forced by the lexical data alone; both require an interpretive commitment. Confidence is medium because the lexical evidence supports two coherent readings, not because the texts are obscure. The data is clear; what is contested is the harmonization rule between the two streams. The fruit/precision nuance: the practical force of both views in real church life is closer than the dispute suggests. Reformed teachers urge perseverance with full pastoral warning. Wesleyan teachers urge confidence in God's preserving grace while acknowledging the real seriousness of warning passages. Both camps produce saints; both camps produce backsliders. The doctrinal question is real but it is not the gospel.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

John.10.28 · **for** · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key term. *κἀγὼ δίδωμι αὐτοῖς ζωὴν αἰώνιον καὶ οὐ μὴ ἀπόλυνται εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα καὶ οὐχ ἄρπάσει τις αὐτὰ ἐκ τῆς χειρὸς μου*; didōmi G1325 present active indicative 1s; zōē G2222; aiōnios G166; apolōntai G622 aorist middle subjunctive 3p with ou mē double negation; harpasei G726 future active indicative 3s; cheir G5495

Force. 'I am giving them eternal life, and they shall absolutely never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand.' Present indicative didōmi marks ongoing-gift. Ou mē plus aorist subjunctive is the emphatic-negation construction, the strongest available denial in Greek: certainty that the perishing will not occur. Future indicative active harpasei reaches into the eschatological frame: no third party can extract the sheep from Christ's hand. The verse is one of the load-bearing pillars of Stream A.

John.10.29 · **for** · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key term. *ὁ πατήρ μου ὃ δέδωκέν μοι μεῖζων πάντων ἐστίν καὶ οὐδεὶς δύναται ἄρπάξειν ἐκ τῆς χειρὸς τοῦ πατρὸς*; dedōken G1325 perfect active indicative 3s; meizōn G3173; harpazein G726 present active infinitive

Force. 'My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all, and no one is able to snatch them out of the Father's hand.' Perfect indicative dedōken marks the abiding-state of the Father's giving. Meizōn pantōn ('greater than all') is the metaphysical guarantee. The two-hands argument (out of my hand v.28, out of the Father's hand v.29) doubles the security.

John.6.39 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. *τοῦτο δὲ ἐστὶν τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με ἵνα πᾶν ὃ δέδωκέν μοι μὴ ἀπολέσω ἐξ αὐτοῦ*; thelēma G2307; pempsantos G3992 aorist active participle; dedōken G1325 perfect active indicative 3s; apolesō G622 aorist active subjunctive 1s

Force. 'This is the will of him who sent me, that of all that he has given me I should lose nothing.' The Father's will is the negative formulation of preservation: lose nothing. The mē apolesō ex autou ('not lose anything from him') is the Son's commission. Combined with v.40 ('I should raise it up on the last day') the preservation extends to bodily resurrection.

Rom.8.30 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. *οὓς δὲ προώρισεν τούτους καὶ ἐκάλεσεν καὶ οὓς ἐκάλεσεν τούτους καὶ ἐδικαίωσεν οὓς δὲ ἐδικαίωσεν τούτους καὶ ἐδόξασεν*; proōrisen G4309 aorist active indicative 3s; ekalesen G2564 aorist active indicative 3s; edikaiōsen G1344 aorist active indicative 3s; edoxasen G1392 aorist active indicative 3s

Force. 'Those whom he predestined he also called; and those whom he called he also justified; and those whom he justified he also glorified.' The golden chain: five verbs all aorist, treating future glorification as accomplished from God's side. The same group passes through every link. Lexically, the construction does not allow attrition: the same houtoi reach the end. The Reformed reading takes this as decisive for perseverance; the Arminian reading takes the aorists as describing a class-pattern rather than every individual.

Rom.8.38 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πέπεισμαι γὰρ ὅτι οὔτε θάνατος οὔτε ζωὴ οὔτε ἄγγελοι οὔτε ἀρχαὶ οὔτε ἐνεστῶτα οὔτε μέλλοντα οὔτε δυνάμεις; pepeismai G3982 perfect passive indicative 1s

Force. 'For I am persuaded that neither death nor life nor angels nor rulers nor things present nor things to come nor powers.' Pepeismai (perfect, abiding conviction). The list of cosmic powers and times reaches as far as the apostle can imagine. Combined with v.39, the list excludes anything in creation from separating the believer from God's love.

Rom.8.39 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὔτε ὕψωμα οὔτε βάθος οὔτε τις κτίσις ἑτέρα δυνήσεται ἡμᾶς χωρίσαι ἀπὸ τῆς ἀγάπης τοῦ θεοῦ τῆς ἐν Χριστῷ Ἰησοῦ; ktisis G2937; chōrisai G5563 aorist active infinitive

Force. 'Nor height nor depth nor any other created thing shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.' Tis ktisis hetera ('any other creature / created thing') is a universal-negative across creation. Chōrisai (aorist infinitive of chōrizō, 'to separate') is the technical separation-term. Stream A reading: nothing external can break the love-bond. Counter-reading: the verse names external threats and does not address whether the believer's own internal apostasy can sever the bond.

Phil.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πεποιθὼς αὐτὸ τοῦτο ὅτι ὁ ἐναρξάμενος ἐν ὑμῖν ἔργον ἀγαθὸν ἐπιτελέσει ἄχρι ἡμέρας Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ; enarxamenos G1728 aorist middle participle nominative masculine singular; ergon G2041; agathon G18; epitelesei G2005 future active indicative 3s

Force. 'Being confident of this very thing, that he who began a good work in you will complete it until the day of Christ Jesus.' Enarxamenos (aorist middle participle, 'having begun') with epitelesei (future indicative active, 'will complete') frames the divine work as initiated and guaranteed-to-be-completed. Achri hēmeras Christou Iēsou ('until the day of Christ Jesus') terminates at the eschaton. Stream A reading: God's initiation entails God's completion. Counter-reading: Paul is expressing pastoral confidence in the Philippian church corporately, not a universal-individual guarantee.

1Pet.1.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. τοὺς ἐν δυνάμει θεοῦ φρουρουμένους διὰ πίστεως εἰς σωτηρίαν ἐτοιμὴν ἀποκαλυφθῆναι ἐν καιρῷ ἐσχάτῳ; phrouroumenous G5432 present passive participle accusative masculine plural; dynamis G1411; pistis G4102; sōtēria G4991

Force. 'Who by God's power are being guarded through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time.' Phroureō is the military-garrison verb (Phil 4:7 of peace garrisoning the heart). Present passive participle phrouroumenous marks ongoing-being-guarded. En dynamei theou ('in God's power') is the means; dia pisteōs ('through faith') is the instrument or condition; eis sōtērian is the goal. Stream A reads dia pisteōs as instrumental: God preserves through the faith he himself sustains. Stream B reads dia pisteōs as conditional: God preserves through faith provided faith continues. Both readings are lexically defensible; the preposition does not settle the dispute.

1John.2.19 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξ ἡμῶν ἐξῆλθαν ἀλλ' οὐκ ἦσαν ἐξ ἡμῶν εἰ γὰρ ἐξ ἡμῶν ἦσαν μεμενῆκεισαν ἂν μεθ' ἡμῶν; exēlthan G1831 aorist active indicative 3p; ēsan G1510 imperfect indicative 3p; memenēkeisan G3306 pluperfect active indicative 3p

Force. 'They went out from us, but they were not of us; for if they had been of us, they would have continued with us.' The pluperfect memenēkeisan with the contrafactual an constructs the Reformed-Stream-A hermeneutic for apparent apostasy: the visible exit of someone from the community demonstrates retroactively that they were never truly in. The verb menō (to remain, abide) is the Johannine perseverance-marker. The Wesleyan reading takes this verse as describing specific antichrists in John's setting (gnosticizing dissenters) rather than a universal rule for all apparent apostasy.

Jude.1.24 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. τῷ δὲ δυναμένῳ φυλάξαι ὑμᾶς ἀπταίστους καὶ στήσαι κατενώπιον τῆς δόξης αὐτοῦ ἀμώμους; phylaxai G5442 aorist active infinitive; aptaistous G679; stēsai G2476 aorist active infinitive; amōmous G299

Force. 'Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy.' Phylaxai (aorist infinitive of phylassō, 'to guard, watch over') with aptaistous ('without stumbling', hapax in NT) and amōmous ('without blemish'). The doxology names God's guarding-capability that terminates in the eschatological presentation. Stream A reads as preservation-promise; Stream B reads as conditional-on-keeping-yourself-in-love (Jude 21).

Heb.6.4 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀδύνατον γὰρ τοὺς ἅπαξ φωτισθέντας γευσάμενους τε τῆς δωρεᾶς τῆς ἐπουρανίου καὶ μετόχους γενηθέντας πνεύματος ἁγίου; adynaton G102; hapax G530; phōtisthentas G5461 aorist passive participle; geusamenous G1089 aorist middle participle; metochous G3353 accusative masculine plural; genēthentas G1096 aorist passive participle

Force. 'For it is impossible to renew again to repentance those who have once been enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and have become partakers of the Holy Spirit.' Hapax phōtisthentas ('once enlightened') is the descriptor of initiation in early Christian usage. Geusamenous tēs dōreas tēs epouraniou ('having tasted the heavenly gift') and metochous pneumatōs hagiou ('partakers of the Holy Spirit') stack five strongly-positive descriptors on the subjects. Stream B reads these as describing real believers who can fall. Stream A reads them as describing those who were once near to salvation without final regeneration, applying 1 John 2:19 retroactively.

Heb.6.6 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. καὶ παραπεσόντας πάλιν ἀνακαινίζειν εἰς μετάνοιαν ἀνασταυροῦντας ἑαυτοῖς τὸν υἱὸν τοῦ θεοῦ καὶ παραδειγματίζοντας; parapesontas G3895 aorist active participle accusative masculine plural; anakainizein G340 present active infinitive; anastaurountas G388 present active participle; paradeigmatizontas G3856 present active participle

Force. 'And then have fallen away, to renew them again to repentance, since they crucify again for themselves the Son of God and put him to open shame.' Parapesontas (aorist participle of parapiptō, 'to fall aside, to apostatize') is the falling-away verb. The construction adynaton plus a series of aorist-passive descriptors plus parapesontas plus the present infinitive anakainizein ('to renew') yields: 'impossible to renew again to repentance the ones who fell away after being enlightened/tasting/partaking.' Stream B reads as straightforward apostasy of real believers; Stream A reads as describing those whose tasting did not reach saving union, with the warning serving as a means of perseverance.

Heb.10.26 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐκουσίως γὰρ ἁμαρτανόντων ἡμῶν μετὰ τὸ λαβεῖν τὴν ἐπίγνωσιν τῆς ἀληθείας οὐκέτι περὶ ἁμαρτιῶν ἀπολείπεται θυσία; hekousiōs G1596; hamartanontōn G264 present active participle; epignōsis G1922; thysia G2378; apoleipetai G620 present passive indicative 3s

Force. 'For if we go on sinning deliberately after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins.' Hekousiōs ('willingly, deliberately') with the present participle hamartanontōn ('continuing to sin') frames habitual deliberate sin. Epignōsis (full-knowledge, definite-knowledge of the truth) is the elevated knowledge-term. The verse's first-person plural hēmōn ('our') applies the warning to the writer and readers, real Christians. Stream B reads as warning to real believers of real loss; Stream A reads as warning to professing Christians whose continued willful sin shows they were not truly believing.

Heb.10.29 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ τὸν υἱὸν τοῦ θεοῦ καταπατήσας καὶ τὸ αἷμα τῆς διαθήκης κοινὸν ἡγησάμενος ἐν ᾧ ἡγιάσθη; katapatēsās G2662 aorist active participle; haima G129; diathēkē G1242; koinon G2839; hēgiasthē G37 aorist passive indicative 3s

Force. 'How much worse punishment do you think will be deserved by the one who has trampled underfoot the Son of God, and has counted the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified a common thing.' En hō hēgiasthē ('by which he was sanctified', aorist passive of hagiāzō) is the load-bearing clause: the apostate is described as having been sanctified by the blood of the covenant. Stream B reads this as decisive: only a real Christian can be described as having been sanctified by Christ's blood. Stream A reads hēgiasthē as covenantal-external sanctification (set apart by visible-covenant membership) without internal regeneration.

Heb.3.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. μέτοχοι γὰρ τοῦ Χριστοῦ γεγόναμεν ἕανπερ τὴν ἀρχὴν τῆς ὑποστάσεως μέχρι τέλους βεβαίαν κατὰσχωμεν; metochoi G3353; gegonamen G1096 perfect active indicative 1p; eanper G1437; archē G746; hypostasis G5287; mechri G3360; telos G5056; bebaian G949; kataschōmen G2722 aorist active subjunctive 1p

Force. 'For we have come to share in Christ if indeed we hold our original confidence firm to the end.' Metochoi tou Christou gegonamen (perfect, 'we have become partakers of Christ') is the indicative of present-status. Eanper plus aorist subjunctive kataschōmen is the conditional: 'if indeed we hold fast.' Stream B reads the conditional as real condition that can fail; Stream A reads it as describing how the elect's perseverance evidences their true partaking.

Heb.3.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. βλέπετε ἀδελφοί μήποτε ἔσται ἐν τινὶ ὑμῶν καρδία πονηρὰ ἀπιστίας ἐν τῷ ἀποστῆναι ἀπὸ θεοῦ ζῶντος; blepete G991 present active imperative 2p; mēpote G3379; apistia G570; apostēnai G868 aorist active infinitive

Force. 'Take care, brothers, lest there be in any of you an evil unbelieving heart, leading you to fall away from the living God.' Blepete (imperative) is the warning-charge addressed to adelphoi ('brothers'). Apostēnai (aorist infinitive of ahistēmi, 'to depart, fall away') with apo theou zōntos ('from the living God') names the apostasy-vector. The audience is the church-community.

2Pet.2.20 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. εἰ γὰρ ἀποφυγόντες τὰ μιάσματα τοῦ κόσμου ἐν ἐπιγνώσει τοῦ κυρίου καὶ σωτῆρος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τούτοις δὲ πάλιν ἐμπλακέντες ἡττώνται; apophygontes G668 aorist active participle; miasmata G3393; epignōsis G1922; emplakentes G1707 aorist passive participle; hēttōntai G2274 present passive indicative 3p

Force. 'If after they have escaped the defilements of the world through the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, they are again entangled in them and overcome, the last state has become worse for them than the first.' Apophygontes ('having escaped') and epignōsei ('full knowledge') describe substantial movement toward Christ. The reversal (palin emplakentes) and the chthonic outcome (hēttōntai, 'they are overcome') describe falling-back. The same epignōsis word as Heb 10:26.

1Tim.1.19 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. ἔχων πίστιν καὶ ἀγαθὴν συνείδησιν ἣν τινες ἀπώσάμενοι περὶ τὴν πίστιν ἐναυάγησαν; pistis G4102; syneidēsis G4893; apōsamēnoi G683 aorist middle participle; enauagēsan G3489 aorist active indicative 3p

Force. 'Holding faith and a good conscience, by rejecting which some have made shipwreck of the faith, among whom are Hymenaeus and Alexander.' Enauagēsan (aorist of nauageō, 'to suffer shipwreck') is a vivid catastrophic-loss metaphor. Peri tēn pistin ('concerning the faith') names what is wrecked. Two named persons are given (1 Tim 1:20: Hymenaeus and Alexander) as case studies in falling.

Col.1.23 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. εἴ γε ἐπιμένετε τῇ πίστει τεθεμελιωμένοι καὶ ἑδραῖοι καὶ μὴ μετακινούμενοι ἀπὸ τῆς ἐλπίδος τοῦ εὐαγγελίου; epimenete G1961 present active indicative 2p; pistis G4102; tethemeliōmenoi G2311 perfect passive participle; hedraioi G1476; metakinoumenoi G3334 present passive participle

Force. 'If indeed you continue in the faith, stable and steadfast, not shifting from the hope of the gospel.' Eige ('if indeed') with present indicative epimenete ('you continue') is a real conditional. The perfect passive tethemeliōmenoi ('having been founded') is set against the present passive metakinoumenoi ('being moved/shifted'). The conditional governs reconciliation in v.22.

John.6.40 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. πᾶς ὁ θεωρῶν τὸν υἱὸν καὶ πιστεύων εἰς αὐτὸν ἔχει ζωὴν αἰώνιον καὶ ἀναστήσω αὐτὸν ἐγὼ τῇ ἑσχάτῃ ἡμέρᾳ; theōrōn G2334 present active participle; pisteuōn G4100 present active participle; echē G2192 present active subjunctive 3s; anastēsō G450 future active indicative 1s

Force. 'For this is the will of my Father, that everyone who looks on the Son and believes in him should have eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day.' Present participles theōrōn and pisteuōn describe continuing-action. Anastēsō (future active 'I will raise') reaches to bodily resurrection. The will of the Father terminates in resurrection, paralleling v.39's 'lose nothing.'

Rom.11.22 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. ἴδε οὖν χρηστότητα καὶ ἀποτομίαν θεοῦ ἐπὶ μὲν τοὺς πεσόντας ἀποτομία ἐπὶ δὲ σὲ χρηστότης θεοῦ ἐὰν ἐπιμένης τῇ χρηστότητι ἐπεί καὶ σὺ ἐκκοπήσῃ; pesontas G4098 aorist active participle; apotomia G663; epimenēs G1961 present active subjunctive 2s; ekkopēsē G1581 future passive indicative 2s

Force. 'Note then the kindness and severity of God: severity toward those who have fallen, but God's kindness to you, provided you continue in his kindness; otherwise you too will be cut off.' Pesontas ('the fallen', aorist participle of piptō) describes the broken-off branches of Israel. Ean epimenēs ('if you continue') is the present-subjunctive condition for the engrafted Gentiles. Ekkopēsē (future passive of ekkoptō, 'you will be cut off') is the lexical threat. Paul applies cutting-off language to those engrafted by faith.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1325, G2222, G166, G622, G726, G5495, G2307, G3992, G4309, G2564, G1344, G1392, G3982, G2937, G5563, G1728, G2005, G2041, G18, G5432, G1411, G4102, G4991, G1831, G3306, G5442, G102, G530, G5461, G1089, G3353, G3895, G340, G388, G3856, G1596, G264, G1922, G2378, G620, G2662, G129, G1242, G2839, G37, G949, G2722, G991, G570, G868, G668, G3393, G1707, G2274, G683, G3489, G1961, G2311, G1476, G3334, G2334, G4100, G2192, G450, G4098, G663, G1581, G5083

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, De Correptione et Gratia, AD 426-427; Augustine's later anti-Pelagian writings developed perseverance more strongly than the earlier fathers · complicates · unverified

“Augustine taught that the elect-predestined receive the gift of perseverance and cannot finally fall; some of the regenerate-not-elect can fall. Early fathers generally assumed possibility of apostasy.”

patristic · Tertullian, De Paenitentia and De Pudicitia; Cyprian, De Lapsis; the Donatist and Novatianist controversies presupposed that real believers could fall and the church debated restoration · denies · unverified

“The lapsed (lapsi) under Decian persecution and the Donatist-Novatianist disputes presupposed real apostasy by real Christians; the patristic church debated restoration, not whether falling was possible at all.”

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent, Session VI on Justification, Canons 23 and 30; Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraph 161, 1861 · denies · unverified

“Trent canon 23 anathematizes saying a once-justified man cannot lose grace. CCC 161 says faith is necessary for salvation, the Lord himself affirms whoever does not believe will be condemned.”

lutheran · Formula of Concord, Solid Declaration Article XI, On the Eternal Predestination and Election of God · complicates · unverified

“Lutheran teaching rejects double predestination and irresistible grace, affirms preservation through means of grace, but allows that faith can be lost; this is a middle position between Reformed and Arminian.”

anglican · 39 Articles of Religion, Article XVI Of Sin after Baptism; Article XVII Of Predestination and Election · complicates · unverified

“Article XVI: not every deadly sin willingly committed after Baptism is sin against the Holy Ghost and unpardonable. Wherefore the grant of repentance is not to be denied to such as fall into sin after Baptism.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith Chapter 17 Of the Perseverance of the Saints, AD 1646; Canons of Dort, Fifth Head of Doctrine, AD 1619 · affirms · unverified

“WCF 17: They whom God has accepted in his Beloved, effectually called and sanctified by his Spirit, can neither totally nor finally fall away from the state of grace, but shall certainly persevere to the end.”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles), Article XII Of Sin after Justification; Wesley sermons on Romans 8 and 1 John · denies · verified

“After we have received the Holy Ghost, we may depart from grace given, and fall into sin, and, by the grace of God, rise again and amend our lives. Verbatim from umc.org Article XII.”

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession 1527; Mennonite Confession of Dordrecht 1632; Anabaptist believers-church tradition generally · complicates · unverified

“Anabaptist tradition affirms genuine faith expressed in discipleship and presupposes the possibility of apostasy; the Schleithem discipline of the ban presupposed real defection by real members.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 5 on Salvation, Article 7 on Sanctification; many Pentecostal bodies hold conditional-security positions, some hold eternal-security positions · complicates · unverified

“Pentecostal tradition is split. The Assemblies of God hold conditional security, salvation can be forfeited. Other Pentecostal bodies (some Baptist-influenced Charismatic streams) hold eternal security. Direct ag.org fetch returned 403.”

eastern_orthodox · Eastern Orthodox synergistic soteriology; theosis tradition; oca.org articles on salvation · denies · unverified

“Eastern Orthodox tradition affirms that salvation requires ongoing cooperation of human free will with divine grace throughout life. Apostasy is genuinely possible; restoration is available through repentance and the sacramental life.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/10-28.htm>

“John 10:28 didōmi (G1325 present active) eternal life; ou mē apolōntai (G622 aorist subjunctive with emphatic double negation); harpasei (G726 future active) no one will snatch from my hand.”

complicates · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_peter/1-5.htm

“1 Pet 1:5 phrouroumenos (G5432 present passive participle) being guarded en dynamei theou (G1411) dia pisteōs (G4102) eis sōtērian (G4991). Dia pisteōs is the contested instrumental-vs-conditional construction.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/1-6.htm>

“Phil 1:6 enarxamenos (G1728 aorist middle participle, 'having begun') epiteleseis (G2005 future active, 'will complete') achri hēmeras Christou Iēsou. God's initiation entails God's completion.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/6-6.htm>

“Heb 6:6 parapesontas (G3895 aorist active participle of parapiptō 'to fall aside, apostatize'); adynaton (G102) palin anakainizein (G340) eis metanoian. Impossible to renew the fallen-away to repentance.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/5083.htm>

“G5083 tēreō: to guard, observe, keep watchful care. Johannine perseverance-verb: John 17:11-12 Christ guards the disciples; Jude 1 kept for Jesus Christ; Jude 21 keep yourselves in the love of God.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/3306.htm>

“G3306 menō: to remain, abide, continue. The Johannine perseverance-marker (John 15:4-7, 1 John 2:19, 1 John 2:24). Stream A and Stream B both depend on this verb; the dispute is whether the remaining is unconditional or conditional.”

opposes · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Article XII Of Sin after Justification: after we have received the Holy Ghost, we may depart from grace given, and fall into sin, and, by the grace of God, rise again and amend our lives. Verbatim Methodist position.”

nuance · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/sd-election/>

“Formula of Concord XI: Lutheran teaching affirms preservation through means of grace, rejects double predestination, allows possibility of apostasy. Middle position between Reformed and Arminian.”

nuance · category: patristic_archive · <https://ccel.org/ccel/augustine/perseverance>

“Augustine De Dono Perseverantiae AD 428-429: perseverance is itself a gift to the elect-predestined. Late-Augustinian doctrine became the seed of Reformed perseverance; early-Augustinian and pre-Augustinian fathers were less developed on this point.”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict
- needs-elder-input